RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Mashiah & the Resurrection

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 5

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, continued: techiyat hametim and the days of Mashiach

Shiur: Part 5 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 28 October 2025

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Recap

The final part of the **secondary** forms of reward and punishment. People focus too much on **this-worldly reward, Gan Eden, Gehinom, Mashiach and resurrection**. **The real thing is Olam HaBa.** Last week: **Gan Eden and Gehinom**, for the Rambam **physical** places on earth, sometime during **resurrection and the Messianic era**. **Tonight:** resurrection and Mashiach, contrasted with other Rishonim. Then back to Olam HaBa.

Part 1: Techiyat Hametim

תחיית המתים הוא יסוד מיסודות משה רבנו עליו השלום, ואין דת ולא דבקות בדת היהודית למי שלא יאמין בזה. אבל היא לצדיקים.

Resurrection is one of the foundations of Moshe Rabbeinu's Torah. One who doesn't believe it has **no religion and no attachment to the Jewish faith. But it is for the righteous.**

Contrast: "I emphasised last week: **Gan Eden and Gehinom are not among the 13 Principles.** In the grand scheme they're **minor**. I know that may sound shocking, **but it's the truth.**" **Resurrection is a foundation.**

Bereishit Rabbah: גבורת גשמים לצדיקים ולרשעים, ותחיית המתים לצדיקים בלבד. Rain falls on everyone, wicked and righteous; **resurrection is for the righteous alone.**

> How could the wicked live again, **when they're dead even in life? ואיך יחיו הרשעים והם מתים אפילו בחייהם רשעים בחייהם קרויים מתים, צדיקים במיתתן קרויים חיים.**

ודע כי האדם יש לו למות בהכרח ויתפרד וישוב למה שהורכב ממנו.

And know that a person must die and disintegrate, returning to what he was made of, even after resurrection.

Point 1: resurrection ends

The Rambam is quite unique here. Nothing **material or physical** can endure forever, and resurrection is **of the body**. So however long it lasts ("a thousand, two thousand years," a figure he'll give for Mashiach),

it's finite.

	The Ramban (and Ramchal, many Rishonim)	The Rambam
Resurrection	Body and soul rise **into Olam HaBa**, a **new world**, and **live forever**	A **finite** period on earth; **the resurrected die again**
His reply to the Rambam	**"Hashem can do miracles.** He can make us live forever, change our bodies' nature"	Philosophically, what's created **must end**; **dust returns to dust**

(Rav Saadia: resurrection also ends, but "let's leave him aside.")

Point 2: then why is it a principle of faith?

If resurrection means living forever, it's obviously foundational. **If it's a temporary period after which you die again, why is it one of the 13?**

The Rambam asks this himself, in the Moreh: because **it's the greatest miracle there can be.** The sea split, but **a dead person living again** is "**the quintessential miracle**." **Not believing it means not believing in miracles, which means not believing in Hashem's *hashgachah*.** "It's **a symptom** of how you understand God operating in the world."

(The prophets' revived child: "it's not entirely clear he'd actually died rather than been unconscious. Leave that aside.")

Point 3: why leave Olam HaBa to come back?

The Rambam's timeline: die today, **begin Olam HaBa immediately**: "no Gan Eden, no Gehinom, **and for sure no *gilgulim***." Mashiach and resurrection are **in the future**. And he's **not tied to 6,000 years**:

"**Rav Saadia** is: the world lasts 6,000 years, so Mashiach must come **in the next 214 years** (it's **5786**). **The Rambam isn't.** The world continues, people are born and die, and everyone from the last 5,786 years **is already in Olam HaBa**."

The famous question: why bring someone *down* from Olam HaBa, the ultimate bliss of **the radiance of the Shechinah**, to live a thousand years on earth? "**However utopian, it's incomparable.**" (For the Ramban, resurrection **is** Olam HaBa; for Rav Saadia, Olam HaBa hasn't begun yet. **Only the Rambam has this problem.**)

Rav Shilat's answer, "**I think you're almost forced to say it**": **there will be *bechirah*, free will, for the resurrected**, and the Rambam is explicit that free will continues in Mashiach's days. **A new opportunity to develop one's character and intellect: that's worth coming down for.** "How there's still free will **after you've tasted Olam HaBa**, I can't answer. **God can do that.**"

A weaker alternative: resurrection exists to **demonstrate** that Hashem performs the greatest miracles. "I find that difficult."

Point 4: who are "the righteous"?

Reading	
Everyone not cut off	Anyone with a portion: most of the Jewish people, "maybe humanity"
Only the very righteous	"**The crème de la crème**": if it's a **second shot**, given after you've **seen** the bliss, perhaps it's reserved for the elite

Either way, the cut-off don't rise. But **sinners with a portion do**, for **Gehinom**'s purging (last week): **Gehinom is on earth, at the resurrection.** "**Otherwise, who's Gehinom for?**"

Questions

Why not use Hilchot Teshuvah's definition of *tzaddik* (merits outweigh sins)?

"Because coming back from Olam HaBa for a second chance is **a huge *chiddush***, and I'm trying to **limit** it. And in the prophets, resurrection sometimes just contrasts righteous and wicked. Hilchot Teshuvah's *rasha* can still have a portion. **I don't think he has that specific definition in mind here. It's possible either way.**"

"It's scary: you earned Olam HaBa, now you're sent back for a thousand years, and could lose it!" *(Rav Dessler asks this in Michtav MeEliyahu.)*

First, a parallel: *gilgul*. "I don't believe in *gilgul*, as the Rambam didn't." If you're reincarnated to fix your sins and come back **worse**, a third time, a fourth? **Rav Chaim Vital** (in the Arizal's name): if you were **70% good, 30% bad**, you return with only **the 30%**, spread across you, so **you can only gain**. "Completely incompatible with the Rambam's framework." *(Rav Chashin of Mir, one of its greatest scholars and a Breslover, told the Rabbi that his tradition is: if you're offered a* gilgul *in Heaven, decline.)*

The Rambam's answer (as the **Nefesh HaChaim** says of pre-sin Eden): Mashiach's era is **free will between good and *better***. Everyone knows Hashem; His presence is **revealed, not hidden**. "**Doing bad will be very difficult. The question is how far you're willing to exert yourself: to go from good to great.** You can't go backwards."

The class: *so the real gain is now, choosing good against bad; then it's extra on top.* "**That fits very nicely: this life is the main thing.**"

On doubting even with clarity: "As a kid I thought: *what's the big test of the Akeidah? If Hashem told me, I'd do it too.* **It's not so simple. We always find a way out**: *maybe He didn't really mean it.* Even after seeing Olam HaBa, we could find a way to doubt."

Part 2: The Days of Mashiach

אמנם ימות המשיח הוא זמן שתשוב המלכות לישראל, ויחזרו לארץ ישראל, ויהיה אותו המלך גדול מאד, ובית מלכותו בציון, ויגדל שמו... יותר מן המלך שלמה, וישלימו עמו כל האומות, ויעבדוהו כל הארצות לצדקו הגדול ולפלאות שיהיו על ידו, וכל מי שיקום עליו ימסרהו השם בידו.

Sovereignty	**Returns to Israel**; all Jews return to the Land
The king	**Very great**, his seat in **Zion**, renowned beyond Shlomo
The nations	Make **peace** with him, drawn by his righteousness and wonders
His enemies	**Hashem delivers them into his hand**

מלך המשיח = **the anointed king**, since kings were anointed with oil. "As we saw **a couple of years ago with King Charles**, anointed with **holy oil from Jerusalem**."

"**A completely sovereign Israel.** No terrorist attacks, nobody at the UN vetoing Israel or **severing diplomatic ties**. **Everyone wants ties with Israel**, everyone wants this king to visit."

Nature doesn't change

ולא ישתנה במציאות דבר ממה שהוא עתה, אלא שהמלכות תחזור לישראל. אין בין העולם הזה לימות המשיח אלא שעבוד מלכויות בלבד.

Nothing changes in nature. There will still be **rich and poor, strong and weak**.

One difference: livelihood will be very easy: **בעמל מעט... יגיע לתועלת גדולה**.

"**This is where the world is heading.** People see **AI and robots** as a threat to work, and from that angle rightly so. **In the Rambam's framework it makes total sense: we're coming to a time when humans won't have to work.** Just switch on the machine."

"Cakes and garments from the trees"

עתידה ארץ ישראל שתוציא גלוסקאות וכלי מילת (Shabbat 30b): *loaves and fine woollen garments*. **Not literal.** It's like saying of someone who comes home to everything cooked: *he found baked bread and a cooked dish*. "**Money growing on trees**: you don't mean it literally; it's that easy." **Proof: ובני נכר אכריכם וכרמיכם** (Yeshayahu): **there will still be farmers and vinedressers**.

Rabban Gamliel and the mushrooms. His student objected: **אין כל חדש תחת השמש**! Rabban Gamliel answered with **mushrooms and truffles**, which spring up overnight. **The Rambam: that wasn't a real answer.** The student had taken it literally, so he **answered a fool according to his folly**. **Mishlei 26:4–5**: **אל תען כסיל כאולתו / ענה כסיל כאולתו**: ignore a foolish question about worldly matters; **answer one about Torah, at his level.**

The real point of Mashiach

והתועלת הגדולה שתהיה באותם הימים, שננוח משעבוד מלכויות, שמונע אותנו מלעשות המצות כולן, ותרבה החכמה... כי מלאה הארץ דעה את ה׳ כמים לים מכסים, ותשבתנה המלחמות, כמו שנאמר: לא ישא גוי אל גוי חרב.

Freedom from subjugation that stops us keeping all the mitzvot; wisdom will increase; **wars will cease.**

The reservists. "A good friend in Israel told me **the batei midrash have been less than half full for the last two years**. Why? **People are out fighting.** How can you develop your intellect while fighting wars? **There won't be wars.**"

Look at these words." In Mashiach's days **we can improve our portion in** "**ונזכה בו לחיי העולם הבא. Olam HaBa**. *What will I do without work?* "**You'll have time to study. That's the greatest joy: time to sit undisturbed and develop your intellect.**"

The king will die

ומשיח ימות, וימלוך בנו תחתיו ובן בנו. dynasty A. **לא יכהה ולא ירוץ עד ישים בארץ משפט**: until he establishes justice; then he'll die. His reign will be **long**, and **people will live longer**, **since worries and sorrows will be gone**. "**Same as today, people living longer**, but more extreme.**"**

ואין לתמוה שתתקיים מלכותו אלפים שנה: it could last two thousand years. קבוץ הטוב קשה פירודו.

Why the prophets longed for it

ואין אנו מתאוים ומקוים לימות המשיח לרוב התבואות והעושר, ולא שנרכב על הסוסים ולא שנשתה היין בכלי שיר, כמו שחושבים מבולבלי הדעת.

Not for abundant crops and wealth, not to ride horses ("**the best cars**") or drink wine with music ("**the best wine**"), **"as the confused think."**

The prophets and the pious longed for it for **the gathering of the righteous**, **good conduct and wisdom**, **the king's justice, wisdom and closeness to God**, and **keeping all the Torah's mitzvot without laziness or compulsion**. "**How many mitzvot can't we keep now? No Temple, no kohanim functioning.**"

ולא ילמדו עוד איש את רעהו... דעו את ה', כי כולם ידעו אותי למקטנם ועד גדולם; ונתתי את תורתי בקרבם ועל לבם אכתבנה; והסרתי את לב האבן מבשרכם.

ובאלה העניינים ישיגו העולם הבא השגה חזקה. Through these, Olam HaBa is attained powerfully.

Key Points on Mashiach

1. **Mashiach is in this world**: everyone agrees. It excludes those who think **Mashiach's days are Olam HaBa**.
2. **The king has military and spiritual roles**: he wins wars and makes treaties, **and teaches Torah**. *(The Rabbi remarked that today there's essentially one group of Jews who both fight and teach Torah.)*
3. **It's a process** (the Moreh; **Gog and Magog**). There may be battles, even **potential messiahs who die**.
4. **A false messiah is one who comes to change the Torah. Shabbetai Tzvi** is the classic case.
5. **Bar Kochba wasn't false**: he tried and **lost**, but didn't change the Torah, and **Rabbi Akiva** supported him.
6. **Jesus** (or his students) **changed the Torah**, so the Rambam calls him a false messiah.
7. **Not supernatural.** That's why **Hilchot Melachim u'Milchamot** holds the laws of Mashiach. They're not in **Sefer HaMada** with resurrection and *Torah min hashamayim*: "**Mashiach is a halachic time.**"
8. **The Rambam's siddur:** after **ובא לציון** ("**if we prayed Shacharit by the Rambam's siddur, I think many more people would come**"):

...שנחיה לשמור חקיך בעולם הזה ולימות המשיח, כדי שנזכה ונירש טובה וברכה לחיי העולם הבא.

May we live to keep Your laws in this world and in the days of Mashiach, so that we merit the life of Olam HaBa.

Will the world end?

He's writing a **thousand years ago** that Mashiach might last **two thousand years**, impossible if the world ends at 6,000. **The Moreh** addresses **שיתא אלפי שני הוו עלמא וחד חרוב** (Sanhedrin):

1. It's **one Sage's** view.

2. **"A thousand years destroyed"**: if the world were gone, **how is there time? Time is part of creation.** So ***charuv*** means **change**, not the end.

3. It may hint at something deeper.

The world likely continues forever.

The Rambam's Whole Timeline

We die	**Immediately into Olam HaBa**, each by his portion
Someday (maybe today)	**The Messianic era**, with **wars**, then **Mashiach**. Those in Olam HaBa **see** it. **Gan Eden, Gehinom and resurrection** happen within it
Its end	The resurrected **die again** and return to Olam HaBa; those who lived through it die and (hopefully) go there
And then	**The earth continues**: 10,000, 20,000, 40,000 years. **People are born, live and die, and go to Olam HaBa: a continuous cycle**

Not all agree there's *bechirah* in Mashiach's days: e.g. Shabbat 151b: **הן ימים אשר תאמר אין לי בהם חפץ — אלו ימות המשיח, שאין בהם לא זכות ולא חובה**. "**No one can reconcile every statement of the Sages. Everyone tries their best.**"

A last question: who recognises Mashiach?

If it's a process, and humans must acknowledge the criteria (the old problem with false messiahs), who decides?

"**Excellent question.** The criteria are very specific (in the Mishneh Torah): military, Torah, and more. **He'll need the majority of Israel to accept him.** *Would the Sanhedrin be reconstituted first?* **I don't know.** If there were a Sanhedrin, it would be simple."

"**We could have a Sanhedrin even now.** We just need the majority of Klal Yisrael to agree who the Sages would be. **They tried 500 years ago**, and couldn't agree. **It would solve so many of our issues**, and be **a good step towards Mashiach**."

Summary

1. **Resurrection is a foundation**: not believing it means **not believing in miracles and *hashgachah***. It's **for the righteous**; **the cut-off don't rise**, though sinners with a portion do, for Gehinom.
2. **For the Rambam alone, resurrection ends**: **the body must die again**. (The Ramban: forever, by miracle.)

3. **Why leave Olam HaBa? A second chance at growth**, free will **between good and better** (Rav Shilat). **This life is the main thing.**
4. **Mashiach**: **sovereignty, peace, ingathering**, a king greater than Shlomo, **in a world whose nature doesn't change**. **Easy livelihood** (AI and robots point the way); "cakes on trees" = **money growing on trees**.
5. **Its purpose: freedom to learn and keep every mitzvah**, and so a **stronger Olam HaBa**. **Not for wealth or wine.**
6. **Mashiach dies**; a dynasty; perhaps **2,000 years**. It's **a process**; a false messiah **changes the Torah**. **Halachic, not supernatural** (Hilchot Melachim).
7. **The world likely continues forever.**

Coming Up

Next week: the paragraph where **"the Rambam's whole philosophy is summarised"** (Olam HaBa again), and then **the 13 Principles of Faith**.

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